When the FA picked his successor, they couldn't have selected anyone more different than the man who'd gone before. I'd always admired the way Kevin Keegan's teams played and enjoyed listening to him talking about the game. I respected his passion and his honesty. I was really excited, joining up with England for the first time with him as manager, for a qualifier against Poland at Wembley. I've always thought that, in a perfect world, it would be good to be able to combine Hoddle's strengths with Keegan's. Glenn is a very good coach who, I think, struggles with relating to some players. Kevin is an absolutely fantastic man manager. Right from the start of our first sessions ahead of that Poland game, Kevin's enthusiasm lifted everyone. He inspired you about what you could do as an England player. Come Saturday and a beautiful spring day at Wembley, everyone was up for it. Scholesy got a hat-trick and we just blew Poland away. I don't think there was anyone in the country who didn't think Kevin was the right man for the England job and all it took was that 3–1 win to convince him to take it on full-time.

There was a great atmosphere around the England camp under Kevin but it was hard work getting to Euro 2000: we ended up having to play off against Scotland. We won 2–0 at Hampden Park on Saturday but then, at Wembley the following Wednesday, Don Hutchison scored for them before half-time and, to be honest, by the end we were hanging on. The important thing, though, was to have qualified. We had six months to forget about how we'd done it and concentrate, instead, on putting things right in time for the Championships in Belgium and Holland. I thought we'd be okay and I had faith in Kevin as England manager. By the time we were squeezing past Scotland, I'd found good reason to put my absolute trust in him as a man, too.

In mid-October 1999, we had one week to play two Euro 2000 qualifiers. We played Luxembourg at Wembley and then four days later, on the Wednesday, we took on Poland in Warsaw. I was in my room at the England hotel on the Friday night before the first of what were going to be two really important games for England. My cell phone rang. It was Victoria, calling from her mum and dad's. She'd have known, the night before a game, that the hotel wouldn't have been allowed to put her through to my room. It didn't help that the line wasn't great but, in amongst the hisses and crackles, I heard what I needed to. The police had been in contact about a tip-off they'd received. They believed someone was going to try and kidnap Victoria and Brooklyn the following day, while I was at Wembley, playing for England. Suddenly, it was like feeling everything was slipping away from beneath me. *What do I do? Who do I tell?* It probably didn't help Victoria that I was so shocked, hardly able to take in what she'd told me. I didn't know what to say, other than: